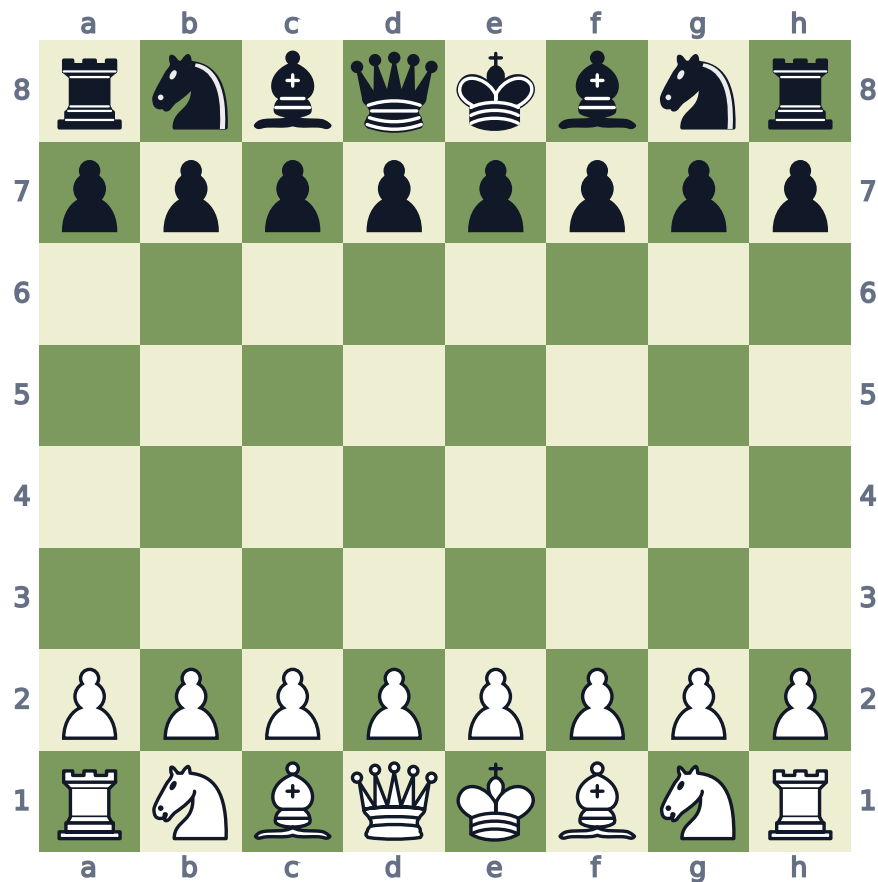


How to Form a Plan

Evaluation that leads to concrete action



Turn positional observations into a plan by choosing an actionable imbalance, improving coordination, and accounting for the opponent's counterplay.

32 learning units | explanations | board laboratories | review system

ORIENTATION

What this course will change

COURSE PROMISE

Turn positional observations into a plan by choosing an actionable imbalance, improving coordination, and accounting for the opponent's counterplay.

YOU WILL LEARN TO

- Perform a balanced evaluation
- Identify the position's most actionable imbalance
- Improve the worst piece
- Create entry squares and useful transformations

HOW TO USE THE COURSE

- Study one learning unit at a time. Say the rule in your own words before continuing.
- At each diagram, hide the model answer. Write candidates and the opponent's best reply.
- Use the rule during a slow game, then record whether it actually changed a decision.
- Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days. Retrieval matters more than rereading.

SCOPE

This course contains 32 integrated learning units. Principles guide attention, but tactics and exact calculation always decide the move.

CORE METHOD

The decision protocol

USE THIS EVERY TIME

A reliable process is more valuable than a brilliant idea used occasionally. Practice the sequence until it becomes automatic under clock pressure.

1**Check tactics first.****2****Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.****3****Name the most important imbalance.****4****Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.****5****Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.****STOPPING RULE**

Choose when one candidate is sufficiently verified for the clock situation. Before moving, inspect the position once from the opponent's perspective.

COURSE MAP

Learning units

- 01 Knights Need Stable Outposts
- 02 Bishops Need Open Diagonals
- 03 The Bishop Pair Prefers Open Positions
- 04 Good and Bad Bishops Depend on Pawn Placement
- 05 Place Rooks on Open Files
- 06 Double Rooks Before Invading
- 07 Coordinate the Queen With Minor Pieces
- 08 Exchange the Opponent's Most Active Piece
- 09 Do Not Trade Your Best Piece Without Compensation
- 10 Reroute a Misplaced Piece
- 11 Material Is Only One Evaluation Factor
- 12 King Safety Is a Dynamic Quantity
- 13 Activity Can Outweigh Structural Damage
- 14 Space Needs a Conversion Method
- 15 The Initiative Belongs to the Side Asking Questions
- 16 Separate Static and Dynamic Advantages
- 17 Choose Which Imbalance to Play Around
- 18 Evaluate Both Sides' Worst Pieces
- 19 A Weakness Requires Access
- 20 Compare Plans by Their Counterplay

COURSE MAP

Learning units

- 21 Derive the Plan from the Pawn Structure
- 22 Choose the Desired Exchange First
- 23 Activate the King in a Quiet Middlegame
- 24 Create the Entry Square Before Taking the File
- 25 Penetrate on the Open File
- 26 Distinguish a Weak Square from an Outpost
- 27 Control the Break Before Starting the Attack
- 28 Use Restraint to Induce Passivity
- 29 Create Targets on Both Wings
- 30 Centralize Before Switching Wings
- 31 Exploit a Color Complex
- 32 Trade Space for Structural Targets

LEARNING UNIT 01

Knights Need Stable Outposts

THE RULE

Route knights toward protected central squares that enemy pawns cannot attack.

WHY IT WORKS

Knights are strongest when their short range reaches important targets without being chased. Stability converts temporary placement into lasting pressure.

RECOGNITION CUES

Closed center; pawn-created hole; protected square on the fifth or sixth rank.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

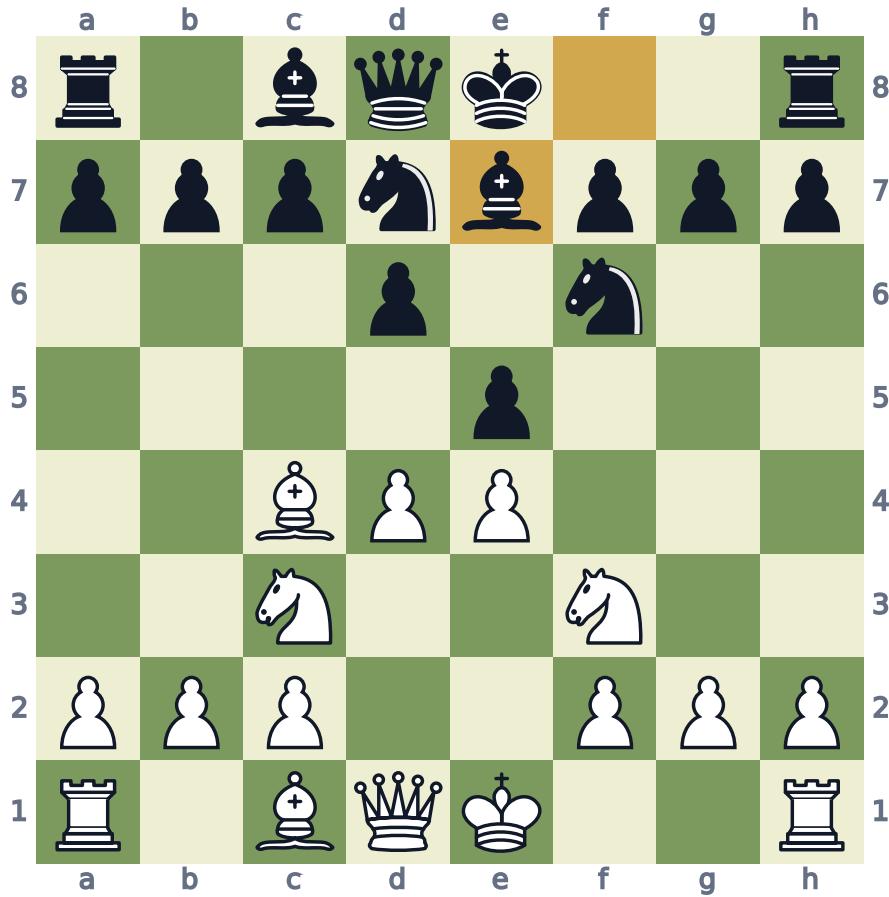
- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

A knight on the rim can be excellent if it has a concrete route or target. Central appearance alone is not enough.

BOARD LABORATORY 01

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



3. d4 Nf6 4. Nc3 Nbd7 5. Bc4 Be7

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Knights Need Stable Outposts'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Knights are strongest when their short range reaches important targets without being chased. Stability converts temporary placement into lasting pressure. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

In ten positions, design a two- or three-move knight route to the best stable square.

LEARNING UNIT 02

Bishops Need Open Diagonals

THE RULE

Use pawn breaks, exchanges, or rerouting to give bishops meaningful scope.

WHY IT WORKS

A bishop's power depends on unobstructed distance. One pawn move can transform it from spectator to attacker across the board.

RECOGNITION CUES

Bishop blocked by its own center; long diagonal can open; opposing pawns sit on its color.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

A restricted bishop can still defend crucial squares or support a future break. Do not trade it automatically.

BOARD LABORATORY 02

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



3... Qd8 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bd3

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Bishops Need Open Diagonals'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A bishop's power depends on unobstructed distance. One pawn move can transform it from spectator to attacker across the board. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

For every bishop in ten positions, count legal squares now and after the most relevant pawn break.

LEARNING UNIT 03

The Bishop Pair Prefers Open Positions

THE RULE

Preserve two bishops when the center is likely to open and targets exist on both colors.

WHY IT WORKS

Together bishops cover both color complexes and can switch wings quickly. Their long range grows as pawns leave the board.

RECOGNITION CUES

Few central pawns; play on both wings; opponent has bishop and knight or two knights.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

In closed positions, knights may dominate before the bishops can open lines. The pair is an asset, not an automatic win.

BOARD LABORATORY 03

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



1... e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. e5

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'The Bishop Pair Prefers Open Positions'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Together bishops cover both color complexes and can switch wings quickly. Their long range grows as pawns leave the board. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Compare ten bishop-pair positions and identify the pawn break that would increase or reduce their value.

LEARNING UNIT 04

Good and Bad Bishops Depend on Pawn Placement

THE RULE

Judge a bishop by whether its own pawns obstruct it and whether it can attack useful targets.

WHY IT WORKS

Pawns on the bishop's color reduce its mobility; enemy pawns on that color can become targets. The label depends on both structures.

RECOGNITION CUES

Locked pawn chains; bishop appears outside the chain; endgame with fixed pawns.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

A 'bad' bishop may be essential defense or become active after one break. A 'good' bishop may attack nothing.

BOARD LABORATORY 04

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



3. e5 Bf5 4. Nf3 e6 5. Be2 c5

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Good and Bad Bishops Depend on Pawn Placement'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Pawns on the bishop's color reduce its mobility; enemy pawns on that color can become targets. The label depends on both structures. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

For ten bishops, write mobility, defensive job, targets, and freeing break before assigning a label.

LEARNING UNIT 05

Place Rooks on Open Files

THE RULE

Use rooks on files without friendly pawns to penetrate or pressure targets.

WHY IT WORKS

Rooks need straight-line access. An open or half-open file gives them range, supports invasion, and forces defensive rook placement.

RECOGNITION CUES

Central pawn exchange; isolated pawn; one file leads to the seventh rank or a weak pawn.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

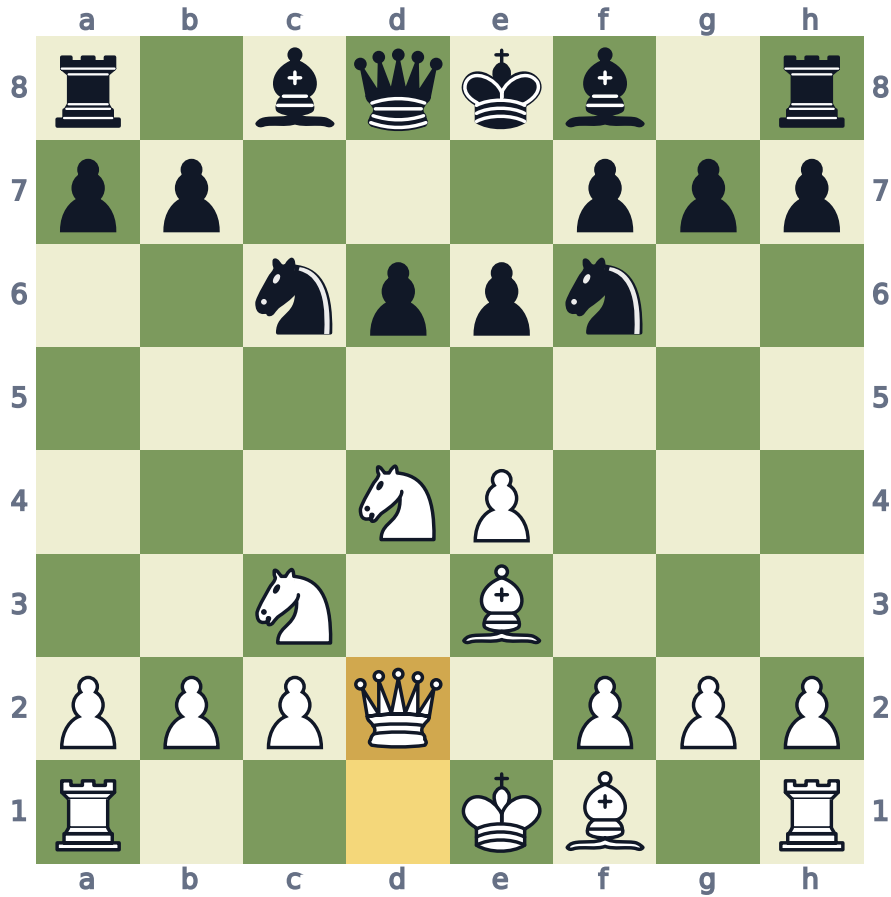
- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

An open file is useful only if it has an entry square or target. A rook may belong behind a passed pawn instead.

BOARD LABORATORY 05

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



4... Nf6 5. Nc3 Nc6 6. Be3 e6 7. Qd2

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Place Rooks on Open Files'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Rooks need straight-line access. An open or half-open file gives them range, supports invasion, and forces defensive rook placement. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

In ten middlegames, rank every open file by entry square, target, and opponent control.

LEARNING UNIT 06

Double Rooks Before Invading

THE RULE

Add a second rook when one rook cannot safely penetrate or win the file alone.

WHY IT WORKS

Doubling increases force and provides recapture support. It can convert nominal file control into an actual invasion.

RECOGNITION CUES

Both sides contest one file; entry square is guarded; queen can help connect rooks.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Do not spend time doubling if one rook can invade immediately or another wing contains an urgent threat.

BOARD LABORATORY 06

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



5. Nc3 a6 6. Be3 e5 7. Nb3 Be6

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Double Rooks Before Invading'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Doubling increases force and provides recapture support. It can convert nominal file control into an actual invasion. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Take ten open-file positions and compare immediate invasion, doubling, and switching files.

LEARNING UNIT 07

Coordinate the Queen With Minor Pieces

THE RULE

Use the queen to amplify piece pressure rather than operating alone.

WHY IT WORKS

A coordinated queen creates batteries, double attacks, and mating nets while minor pieces cover squares the queen cannot occupy safely.

RECOGNITION CUES

Bishop points toward king; knight controls flight squares; queen can join without being chased.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

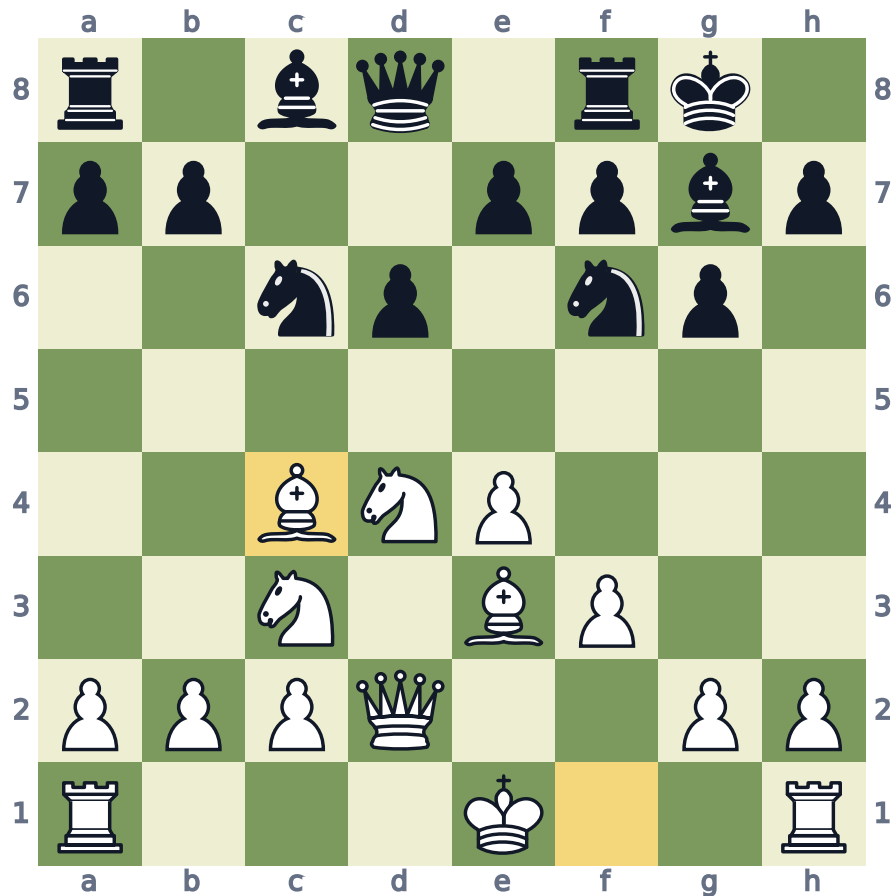
- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Queen activity can become exposure. If minor pieces are undeveloped, the queen may simply provide the opponent tempi.

BOARD LABORATORY 07

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



6... Bg7 7. f3 O-O 8. Qd2 Nc6 9. Bc4

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Coordinate the Queen With Minor Pieces'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A coordinated queen creates batteries, double attacks, and mating nets while minor pieces cover squares the queen cannot occupy safely. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

In ten attacks, identify the minor piece that makes the queen's threat possible.

LEARNING UNIT 08

Exchange the Opponent's Most Active Piece

THE RULE

When under positional pressure, seek a favorable trade of the enemy piece doing the most work.

WHY IT WORKS

Removing the active unit reduces threats and may expose the weakness it was supporting. Activity, not nominal piece value, determines urgency.

RECOGNITION CUES

One knight dominates an outpost; a bishop controls both wings; a rook occupies the seventh rank.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Do not trade your only active defender or enter a worse pawn ending merely to remove an impressive piece.

BOARD LABORATORY 08

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



2... d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Exchange the Opponent's Most Active Piece'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Removing the active unit reduces threats and may expose the weakness it was supporting. Activity, not nominal piece value, determines urgency. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

In ten positions, name each side's most active piece and calculate one realistic exchange route.

LEARNING UNIT 09

Do Not Trade Your Best Piece Without Compensation

THE RULE

Preserve the piece that creates your activity unless the exchange wins material, structure, safety, or a favorable ending.

WHY IT WORKS

An active piece may hold the entire position together. Trading it can eliminate pressure and leave only structural weaknesses.

RECOGNITION CUES

Your best piece is offered a trade; simplification looks convenient; one piece controls critical squares.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

A strong piece should be traded when it removes an even more important defender or converts an advantage cleanly.

BOARD LABORATORY 09

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e6 6. Be2 Be7

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Do Not Trade Your Best Piece Without Compensation'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: An active piece may hold the entire position together. Trading it can eliminate pressure and leave only structural weaknesses. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Review ten voluntary exchanges and compare the activity map before and after the trade.

LEARNING UNIT 10

Reroute a Misplaced Piece

THE RULE

Spend time correcting a piece with no useful future rather than pretending it will become relevant.

WHY IT WORKS

A bad placement imposes a recurring tax on the whole position. A multi-move reroute can unlock pawn breaks and coordination.

RECOGNITION CUES

Piece has few legal squares; attacks no target; blocks a rook or pawn; another stable route exists.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

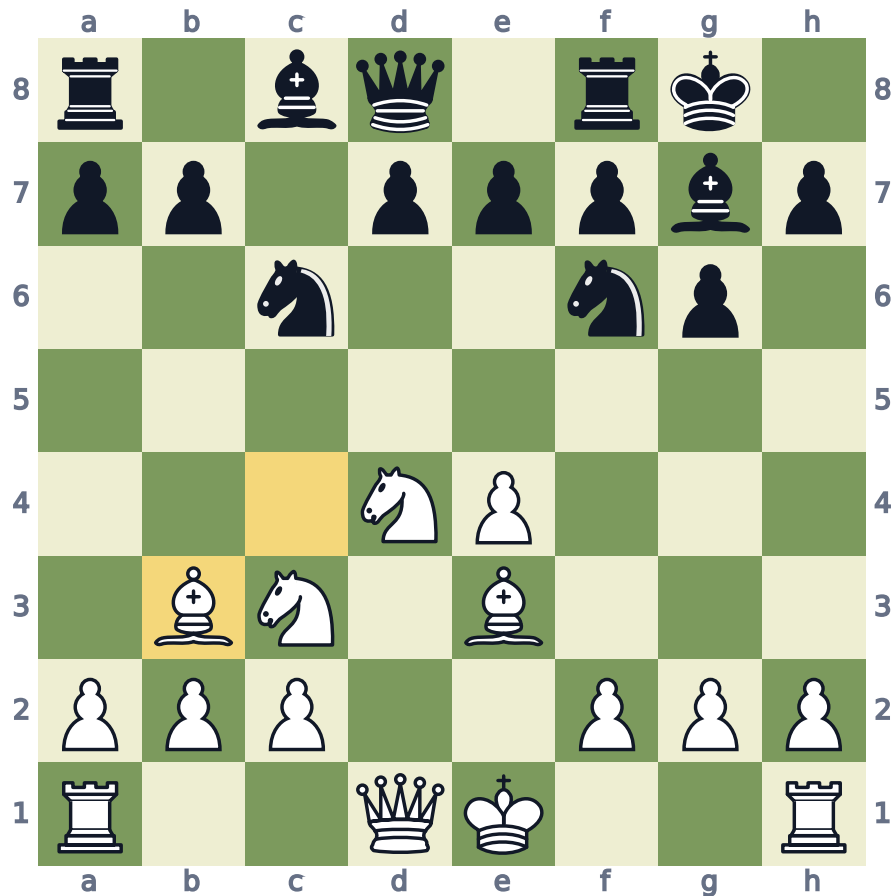
- Check tactics first.
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- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Do not begin a long maneuver during a tactical crisis or when the opponent can open the position first.

BOARD LABORATORY 10

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



5... Bg7 6. Be3 Nf6 7. Bc4 O-O 8. Bb3

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Reroute a Misplaced Piece'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A bad placement imposes a recurring tax on the whole position. A multi-move reroute can unlock pawn breaks and coordination. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

In ten quiet positions, find the least useful piece and draw its best three-square route.

LEARNING UNIT 11

Material Is Only One Evaluation Factor

THE RULE

Balance material against king safety, activity, structure, space, and forcing initiative.

WHY IT WORKS

Material is durable but temporarily inactive pieces may contribute nothing. Dynamic advantages can justify deficits when they create concrete pressure or recovery.

RECOGNITION CUES

No forcing tactic decides the move; the candidates produce different imbalances; the position is changing from opening to middlegame

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Evaluation factors interact. Never add them mechanically or let a static feature hide immediate king danger and tactical activity.

BOARD LABORATORY 11

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



2. Nf3 e6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nc6

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Material Is Only One Evaluation Factor'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Material is durable but temporarily inactive pieces may contribute nothing. Dynamic advantages can justify deficits when they create concrete pressure or recovery. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Evaluate ten quiet positions through the lens of material is only one evaluation factor. Give a verdict, best plan, and one condition that would reverse the verdict.

LEARNING UNIT 12

King Safety Is a Dynamic Quantity

THE RULE

Judge king safety by accessible lines, attacking force, defenders, and escape squares rather than pawn appearance alone.

WHY IT WORKS

An intact pawn shield can be unsafe when lines and attackers are ready, while an exposed king may be safe after queens are exchanged.

RECOGNITION CUES

No forcing tactic decides the move; the candidates produce different imbalances; the position is changing from opening to middlegame

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Evaluation factors interact. Never add them mechanically or let a static feature hide immediate king danger and tactical activity.

BOARD LABORATORY 12

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 a6 5. Bd3 Qc7

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'King Safety Is a Dynamic Quantity'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: An intact pawn shield can be unsafe when lines and attackers are ready, while an exposed king may be safe after queens are exchanged. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Evaluate ten quiet positions through the lens of king safety is a dynamic quantity. Give a verdict, best plan, and one condition that would reverse the verdict.

LEARNING UNIT 13

Activity Can Outweigh Structural Damage

THE RULE

Accept a structural defect when it produces sustained piece activity or open lines that the opponent cannot neutralize.

WHY IT WORKS

Weak pawns matter only if they can be attacked. Active pieces may seize the initiative, create threats, and prevent the opponent from organizing against the structure.

RECOGNITION CUES

No forcing tactic decides the move; the candidates produce different imbalances; the position is changing from opening to middlegame

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

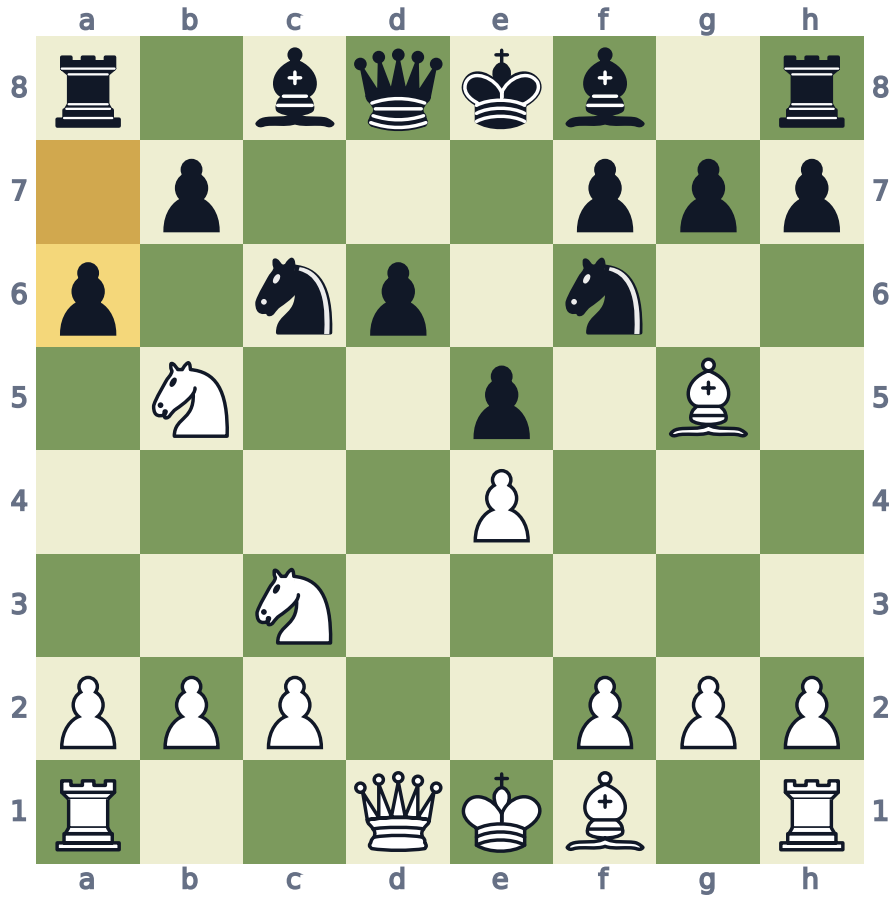
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- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Evaluation factors interact. Never add them mechanically or let a static feature hide immediate king danger and tactical activity.

BOARD LABORATORY 13

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



5. Nc3 e5 6. Ndb5 d6 7. Bg5 a6

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Activity Can Outweigh Structural Damage'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Weak pawns matter only if they can be attacked. Active pieces may seize the initiative, create threats, and prevent the opponent from organizing against the structure. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Evaluate ten quiet positions through the lens of activity can outweigh structural damage. Give a verdict, best plan, and one condition that would reverse the verdict.

LEARNING UNIT 14

Space Needs a Conversion Method

THE RULE

Value extra territory by the piece improvements and pawn breaks it enables.

WHY IT WORKS

Space restricts the opponent and grants maneuvering room, but it can become overextension if no breakthrough or useful route exists.

RECOGNITION CUES

No forcing tactic decides the move; the candidates produce different imbalances; the position is changing from opening to middlegame

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

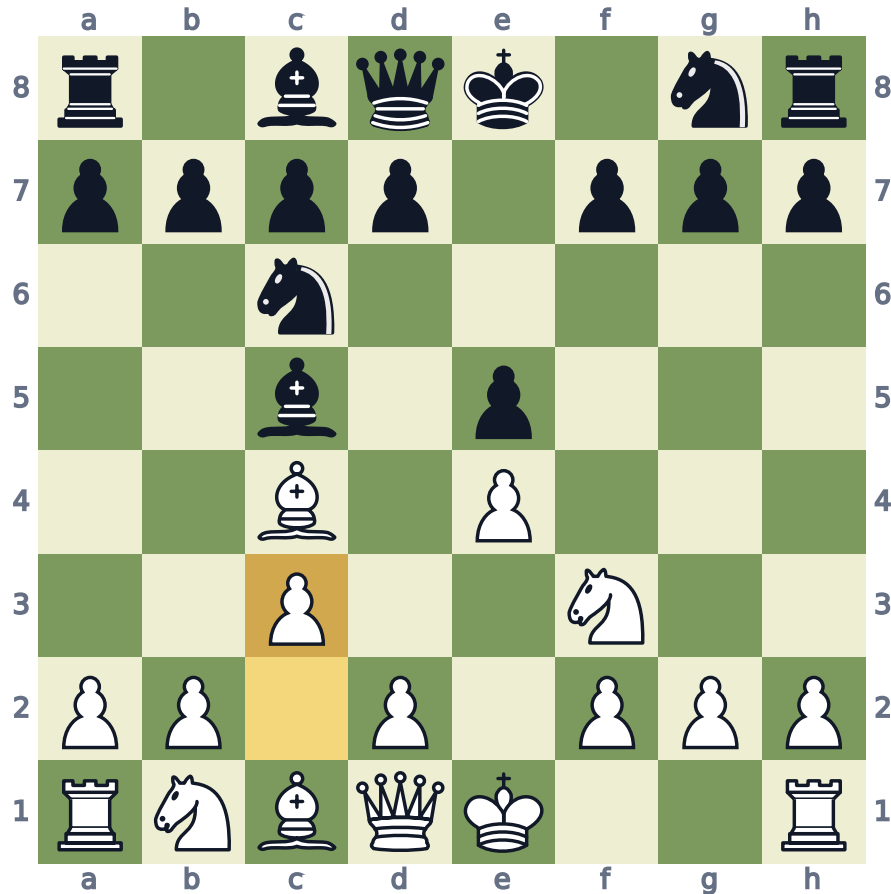
- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Evaluation factors interact. Never add them mechanically or let a static feature hide immediate king danger and tactical activity.

BOARD LABORATORY 14

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



1... e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. c3

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Space Needs a Conversion Method'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Space restricts the opponent and grants maneuvering room, but it can become overextension if no breakthrough or useful route exists. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Evaluate ten quiet positions through the lens of space needs a conversion method. Give a verdict, best plan, and one condition that would reverse the verdict.

LEARNING UNIT 15

The Initiative Belongs to the Side Asking Questions

THE RULE

Identify which side creates threats that force replies and how long that sequence can continue.

WHY IT WORKS

Initiative is control of move purpose. The responding side spends tempi neutralizing threats instead of improving its own position.

RECOGNITION CUES

No forcing tactic decides the move; the candidates produce different imbalances; the position is changing from opening to middlegame

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

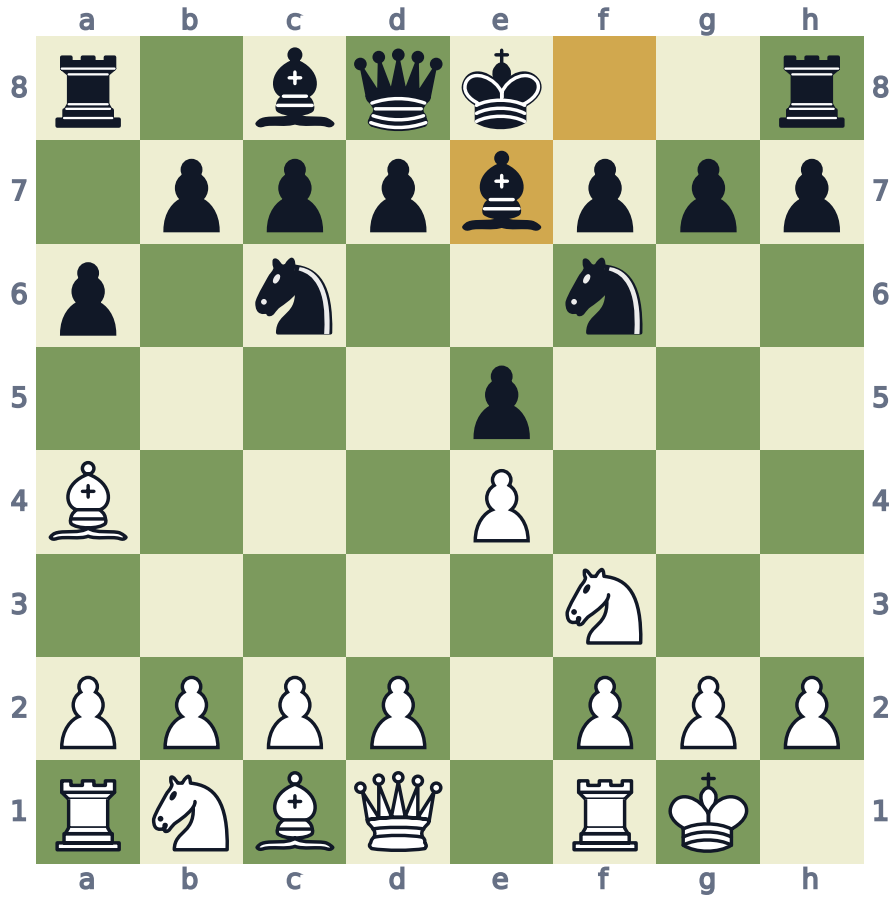
- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Evaluation factors interact. Never add them mechanically or let a static feature hide immediate king danger and tactical activity.

BOARD LABORATORY 15

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'The Initiative Belongs to the Side Asking Questions'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Initiative is control of move purpose. The responding side spends tempi neutralizing threats instead of improving its own position. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Evaluate ten quiet positions through the lens of the initiative belongs to the side asking questions. Give a verdict, best plan, and one condition that would reverse the verdict.

LEARNING UNIT 16

Separate Static and Dynamic Advantages

THE RULE

Classify advantages by whether they persist automatically or require immediate energetic play.

WHY IT WORKS

Static features such as a weak pawn can last; dynamic features such as development and initiative decay. The correct plan depends on the advantage's time horizon.

RECOGNITION CUES

No forcing tactic decides the move; the candidates produce different imbalances; the position is changing from opening to middlegame

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

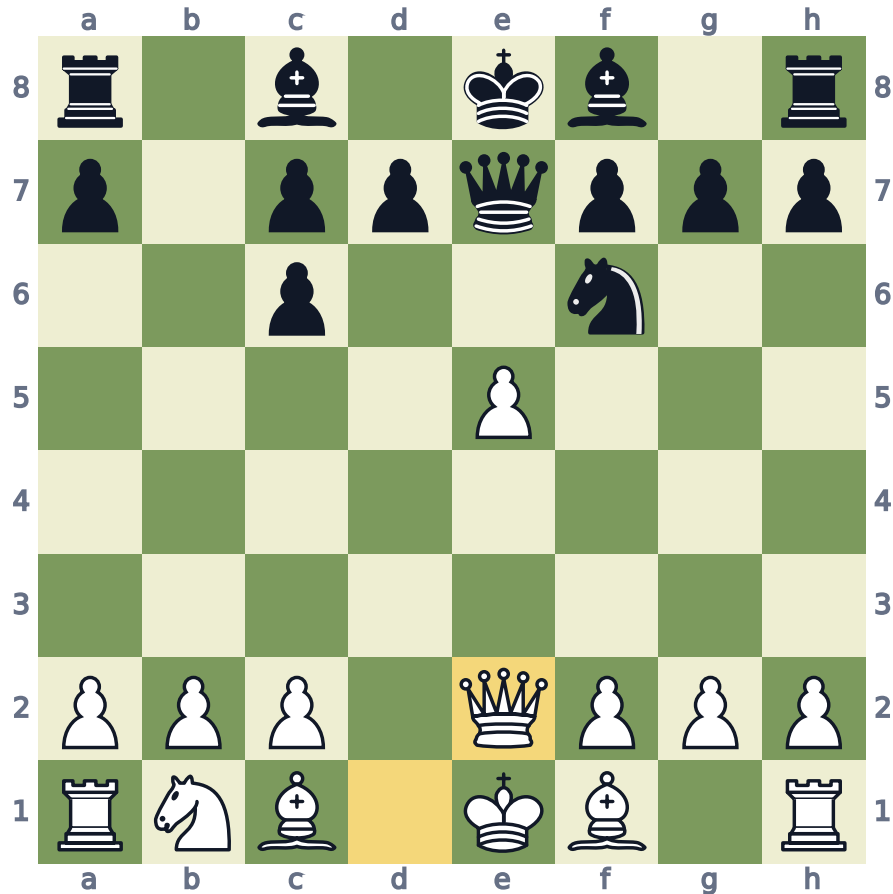
- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Evaluation factors interact. Never add them mechanically or let a static feature hide immediate king danger and tactical activity.

BOARD LABORATORY 16

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



4... Nf6 5. Nxc6 bxc6 6. e5 Qe7 7. Qe2

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Separate Static and Dynamic Advantages'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Static features such as a weak pawn can last; dynamic features such as development and initiative decay. The correct plan depends on the advantage's time horizon. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Evaluate ten quiet positions through the lens of separate static and dynamic advantages. Give a verdict, best plan, and one condition that would reverse the verdict.

LEARNING UNIT 17

Choose Which Imbalance to Play Around

THE RULE

Select the material, structural, spatial, or piece-quality difference most capable of producing a plan.

WHY IT WORKS

Positions contain many differences, but not all are actionable. A useful imbalance points to targets, favorable exchanges, and piece routes.

RECOGNITION CUES

No forcing tactic decides the move; the candidates produce different imbalances; the position is changing from opening to middlegame

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

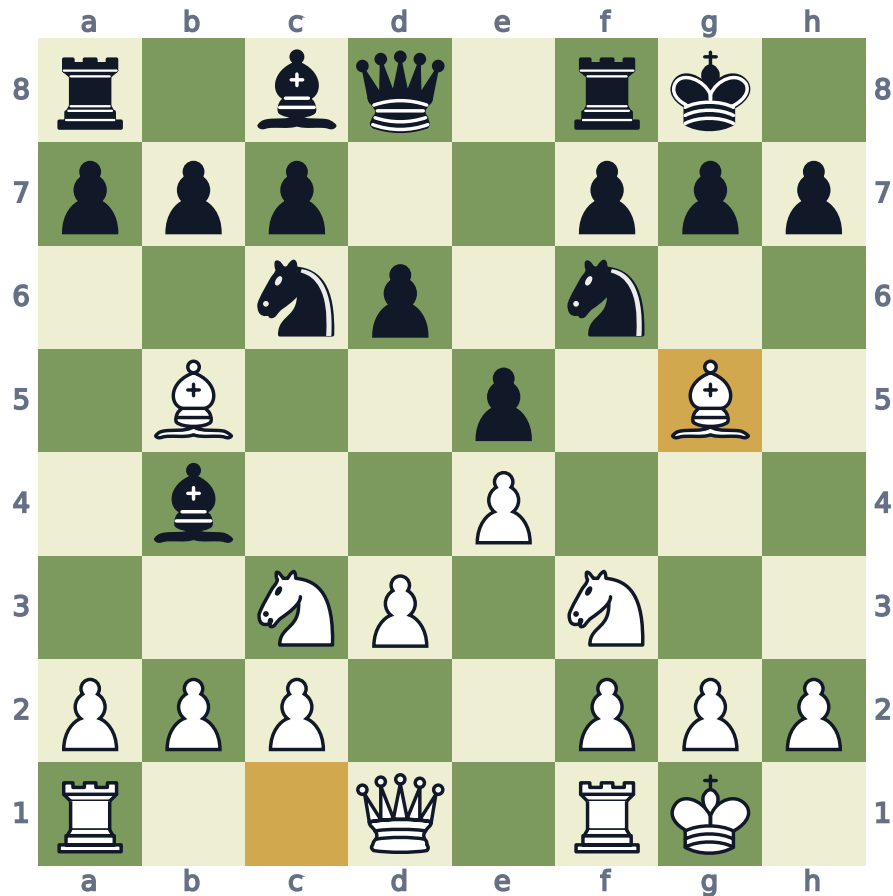
- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Evaluation factors interact. Never add them mechanically or let a static feature hide immediate king danger and tactical activity.

BOARD LABORATORY 17

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



4... Bb4 5. O-O O-O 6. d3 d6 7. Bg5

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Choose Which Imbalance to Play Around'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Positions contain many differences, but not all are actionable. A useful imbalance points to targets, favorable exchanges, and piece routes. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Evaluate ten quiet positions through the lens of choose which imbalance to play around. Give a verdict, best plan, and one condition that would reverse the verdict.

LEARNING UNIT 18

Evaluate Both Sides' Worst Pieces

THE RULE

Compare the least effective piece on each side and the ease with which it can improve.

WHY IT WORKS

A nominal advantage may disappear if the opponent can activate quickly. The relative improvement race reveals whose position has more hidden potential.

RECOGNITION CUES

No forcing tactic decides the move; the candidates produce different imbalances; the position is changing from opening to middlegame

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Evaluation factors interact. Never add them mechanically or let a static feature hide immediate king danger and tactical activity.

BOARD LABORATORY 18

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



1... e5 2. Nc3 Nf6 3. f4 d5 4. fxe5

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Evaluate Both Sides' Worst Pieces'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A nominal advantage may disappear if the opponent can activate quickly. The relative improvement race reveals whose position has more hidden potential. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Evaluate ten quiet positions through the lens of evaluate both sides' worst pieces. Give a verdict, best plan, and one condition that would reverse the verdict.

LEARNING UNIT 19

A Weakness Requires Access

THE RULE

Call a pawn or square weak only when the opponent can reach and exploit it without excessive cost.

WHY IT WORKS

Static labels become meaningful through routes. If no piece can attack the weakness or invasion square is unavailable, the defect may be irrelevant.

RECOGNITION CUES

No forcing tactic decides the move; the candidates produce different imbalances; the position is changing from opening to middlegame

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Evaluation factors interact. Never add them mechanically or let a static feature hide immediate king danger and tactical activity.

BOARD LABORATORY 19

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



4. h4 g4 5. Ne5 Nf6 6. Bc4 d5

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'A Weakness Requires Access'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Static labels become meaningful through routes. If no piece can attack the weakness or invasion square is unavailable, the defect may be irrelevant. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Evaluate ten quiet positions through the lens of a weakness requires access. Give a verdict, best plan, and one condition that would reverse the verdict.

LEARNING UNIT 20

Compare Plans by Their Counterplay

THE RULE

Evaluate a plan partly by the opponent's strongest active response.

WHY IT WORKS

A plan that makes progress while suppressing counterplay is easier to execute than one that gains more but releases dangerous activity.

RECOGNITION CUES

No forcing tactic decides the move; the candidates produce different imbalances; the position is changing from opening to middlegame

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Evaluation factors interact. Never add them mechanically or let a static feature hide immediate king danger and tactical activity.

BOARD LABORATORY 20

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



4. Nf3 Nxe4 5. d4 d5 6. Bd3 Bd6

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Compare Plans by Their Counterplay'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A plan that makes progress while suppressing counterplay is easier to execute than one that gains more but releases dangerous activity. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Evaluate ten quiet positions through the lens of compare plans by their counterplay. Give a verdict, best plan, and one condition that would reverse the verdict.

LEARNING UNIT 21

Derive the Plan from the Pawn Structure

THE RULE

Read the fixed pawn skeleton before choosing where to maneuver or attack.

WHY IT WORKS

Pawns determine space, open files, weak squares, and likely breaks. Because they move slowly and cannot retreat, their arrangement predicts which piece placements and wing operations will remain useful.

RECOGNITION CUES

there is no immediate forcing sequence; the pawn structure is stable; one side can improve a piece or create a lasting target

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Strategic gains are too slow if the opponent has a concrete break, attack, or tactical resource. Recheck forcing moves whenever the position changes.

BOARD LABORATORY 21

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



1... e5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 Nf6 4. Nc3

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Derive the Plan from the Pawn Structure'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Pawns determine space, open files, weak squares, and likely breaks. Because they move slowly and cannot retreat, their arrangement predicts which piece placements and wing operations will remain useful. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Collect twelve positions connected to 'Derive the Plan from the Pawn Structure'. For each, write three candidates, the opponent's strongest reply, and a one-sentence evaluation. Revisit the same positions without notes after three and seven...

LEARNING UNIT 22

Choose the Desired Exchange First

THE RULE

Decide which exchange improves the resulting position before maneuvering to make it happen.

WHY IT WORKS

Exchanges are strategic transformations, not automatic simplifications. Naming the favorable trade clarifies routes and prevents aimless improving moves that accidentally remove your best piece.

RECOGNITION CUES

there is no immediate forcing sequence; the pawn structure is stable; one side can improve a piece or create a lasting target

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Strategic gains are too slow if the opponent has a concrete break, attack, or tactical resource. Recheck forcing moves whenever the position changes.

BOARD LABORATORY 22

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



1... d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qd8 4. d4

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Choose the Desired Exchange First'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Exchanges are strategic transformations, not automatic simplifications. Naming the favorable trade clarifies routes and prevents aimless improving moves that accidentally remove your best piece. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Collect twelve positions connected to 'Choose the Desired Exchange First'. For each, write three candidates, the opponent's strongest reply, and a one-sentence evaluation. Revisit the same positions without notes after three and seven...

LEARNING UNIT 23

Activate the King in a Quiet Middlegame

THE RULE

When queens are off and tactics permit, improve the king before the formal endgame begins.

WHY IT WORKS

A centralized king shortens future routes, supports pawn breaks, and frees other pieces from defensive work. One anticipatory king move can save several tempi after further exchanges.

RECOGNITION CUES

there is no immediate forcing sequence; the pawn structure is stable; one side can improve a piece or create a lasting target

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Strategic gains are too slow if the opponent has a concrete break, attack, or tactical resource. Recheck forcing moves whenever the position changes.

BOARD LABORATORY 23

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



4... Nfd7 5. f4 c5 6. Nf3 Nc6 7. Be3

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Activate the King in a Quiet Middlegame'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A centralized king shortens future routes, supports pawn breaks, and frees other pieces from defensive work. One anticipatory king move can save several tempi after further exchanges. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Collect twelve positions connected to 'Activate the King in a Quiet Middlegame'. For each, write three candidates, the opponent's strongest reply, and a one-sentence evaluation. Revisit the same positions without notes after three and seven...

LEARNING UNIT 24

Create the Entry Square Before Taking the File

THE RULE

An open file matters only if your heavy pieces can enter the opponent's position through it.

WHY IT WORKS

Mere occupation can be neutralized by equal rooks. Controlling a seventh-rank square or forcing a defender away converts the file from visual space into penetration and targets.

RECOGNITION CUES

there is no immediate forcing sequence; the pawn structure is stable; one side can improve a piece or create a lasting target

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Strategic gains are too slow if the opponent has a concrete break, attack, or tactical resource. Recheck forcing moves whenever the position changes.

BOARD LABORATORY 24

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



1... c6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 Bf5 4. Nf3

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Create the Entry Square Before Taking the File'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Mere occupation can be neutralized by equal rooks. Controlling a seventh-rank square or forcing a defender away converts the file from visual space into penetration and targets. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Collect twelve positions connected to 'Create the Entry Square Before Taking the File'. For each, write three candidates, the opponent's strongest reply, and a one-sentence evaluation. Revisit the same positions without notes after three and...

LEARNING UNIT 25

Penetrate on the Open File

THE RULE

Double rooks or invade only when doing so creates a concrete target, tie-down, or favorable exchange.

WHY IT WORKS

Heavy pieces gain value from access. Penetration forces defensive passivity and attacks pawns from the side or rear, whereas an open file with no entry points may be strategically irrelevant.

RECOGNITION CUES

there is no immediate forcing sequence; the pawn structure is stable; one side can improve a piece or create a lasting target

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Strategic gains are too slow if the opponent has a concrete break, attack, or tactical resource. Recheck forcing moves whenever the position changes.

BOARD LABORATORY 25

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 Nc6

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Penetrate on the Open File'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Heavy pieces gain value from access. Penetration forces defensive passivity and attacks pawns from the side or rear, whereas an open file with no entry points may be strategically irrelevant. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Collect twelve positions connected to 'Penetrate on the Open File'. For each, write three candidates, the opponent's strongest reply, and a one-sentence evaluation. Revisit the same positions without notes after three and seven days; scor...

LEARNING UNIT 26

Distinguish a Weak Square from an Outpost

THE RULE

Call a square an outpost only when a piece can occupy it safely and do useful work there.

WHY IT WORKS

A square may be impossible to challenge with a pawn yet still be inaccessible, exchangeable, or irrelevant. Usability-the route, stability, and targets-turns an abstract hole into an asset.

RECOGNITION CUES

there is no immediate forcing sequence; the pawn structure is stable; one side can improve a piece or create a lasting target

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Strategic gains are too slow if the opponent has a concrete break, attack, or tactical resource. Recheck forcing moves whenever the position changes.

BOARD LABORATORY 26

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Distinguish a Weak Square from an Outpost'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A square may be impossible to challenge with a pawn yet still be inaccessible, exchangeable, or irrelevant. Usability—the route, stability, and targets—turns an abstract hole into an asset. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Collect twelve positions connected to 'Distinguish a Weak Square from an Outpost'. For each, write three candidates, the opponent's strongest reply, and a one-sentence evaluation. Revisit the same positions without notes after three and seven...

LEARNING UNIT 27

Control the Break Before Starting the Attack

THE RULE

Prevent or answer the opponent's freeing pawn break before committing pieces elsewhere.

WHY IT WORKS

A cramped defender is often one pawn break away from activity. Restraining that break preserves the spatial bind and buys the time required for a wing attack or slow regrouping.

RECOGNITION CUES

there is no immediate forcing sequence; the pawn structure is stable; one side can improve a piece or create a lasting target

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Strategic gains are too slow if the opponent has a concrete break, attack, or tactical resource. Recheck forcing moves whenever the position changes.

BOARD LABORATORY 27

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



3... cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 g6 6. Be3

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Control the Break Before Starting the Attack'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A cramped defender is often one pawn break away from activity. Restraining that break preserves the spatial bind and buys the time required for a wing attack or slow regrouping. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Collect twelve positions connected to 'Control the Break Before Starting the Attack'. For each, write three candidates, the opponent's strongest reply, and a one-sentence evaluation. Revisit the same positions without notes after three and seven days.

LEARNING UNIT 28

Use Restraint to Induce Passivity

THE RULE

Take away the opponent's active breaks and piece routes before attacking fixed weaknesses.

WHY IT WORKS

A weakness is easier to exploit when its defenders have no counterplay. Restraint turns pieces into guards, after which you can improve at leisure and create a second point of contact.

RECOGNITION CUES

there is no immediate forcing sequence; the pawn structure is stable; one side can improve a piece or create a lasting target

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

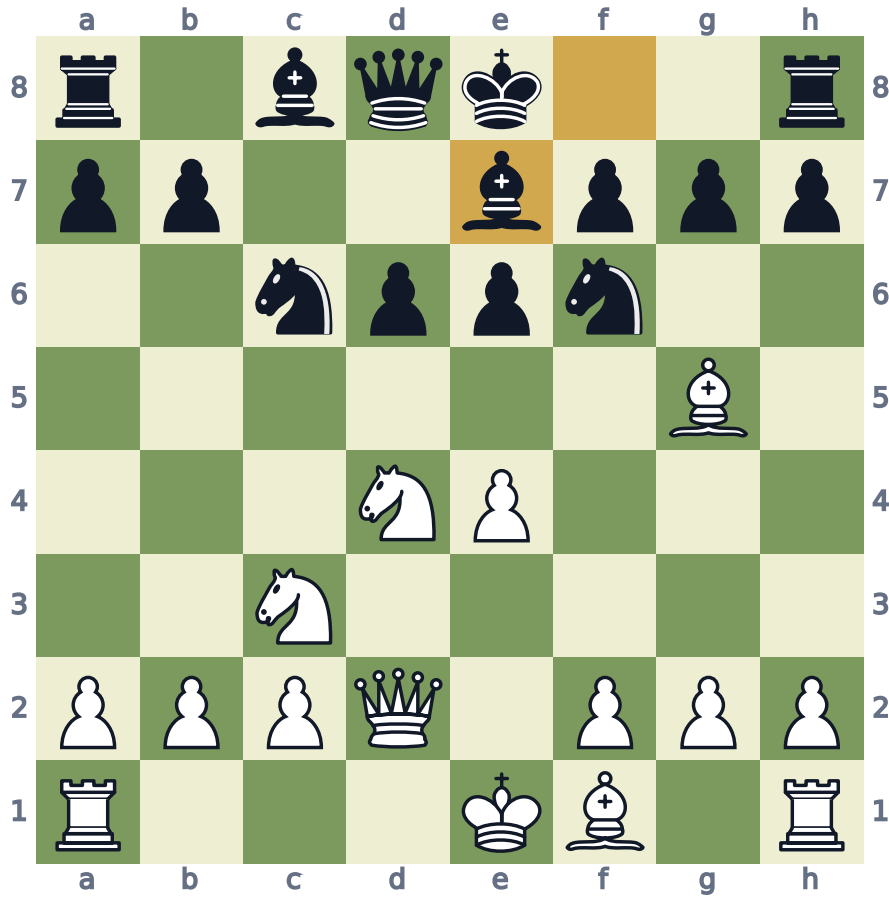
- Check tactics first.
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- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Strategic gains are too slow if the opponent has a concrete break, attack, or tactical resource. Recheck forcing moves whenever the position changes.

BOARD LABORATORY 28

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



5. Nc3 Nc6 6. Bg5 e6 7. Qd2 Be7

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Use Restraint to Induce Passivity'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A weakness is easier to exploit when its defenders have no counterplay. Restraint turns pieces into guards, after which you can improve at leisure and create a second point of contact. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Collect twelve positions connected to 'Use Restraint to Induce Passivity'. For each, write three candidates, the opponent's strongest reply, and a one-sentence evaluation. Revisit the same positions without notes after three and seven days; scor...

LEARNING UNIT 29

Create Targets on Both Wings

THE RULE

When one weakness is fully defended, create a second weakness far from it.

WHY IT WORKS

Defenders can concentrate against one target. Two distant targets stretch king and pieces across the board, producing a moment when one side cannot be reinforced in time.

RECOGNITION CUES

there is no immediate forcing sequence; the pawn structure is stable; one side can improve a piece or create a lasting target

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

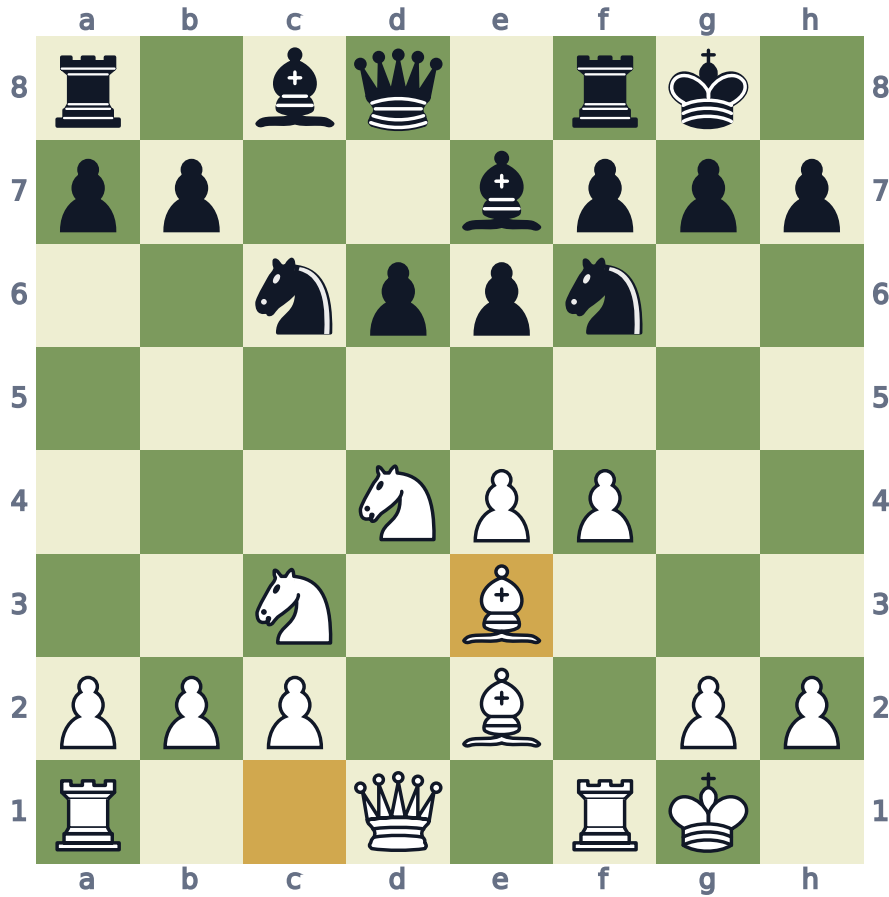
- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Strategic gains are too slow if the opponent has a concrete break, attack, or tactical resource. Recheck forcing moves whenever the position changes.

BOARD LABORATORY 29

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



6... Be7 7. O-O O-O 8. f4 Nc6 9. Be3

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Create Targets on Both Wings'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Defenders can concentrate against one target. Two distant targets stretch king and pieces across the board, producing a moment when one side cannot be reinforced in time. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Collect twelve positions connected to 'Create Targets on Both Wings'. For each, write three candidates, the opponent's strongest reply, and a one-sentence evaluation. Revisit the same positions without notes after three and seven days; scor...

LEARNING UNIT 30

Centralize Before Switching Wings

THE RULE

Place pieces on central routes before transferring the attack from one flank to the other.

WHY IT WORKS

Central pieces have shorter paths to both wings. This flexibility makes the switch faster than the defender's lateral regrouping and reduces the risk that a flank piece becomes stranded.

RECOGNITION CUES

there is no immediate forcing sequence; the pawn structure is stable; one side can improve a piece or create a lasting target

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

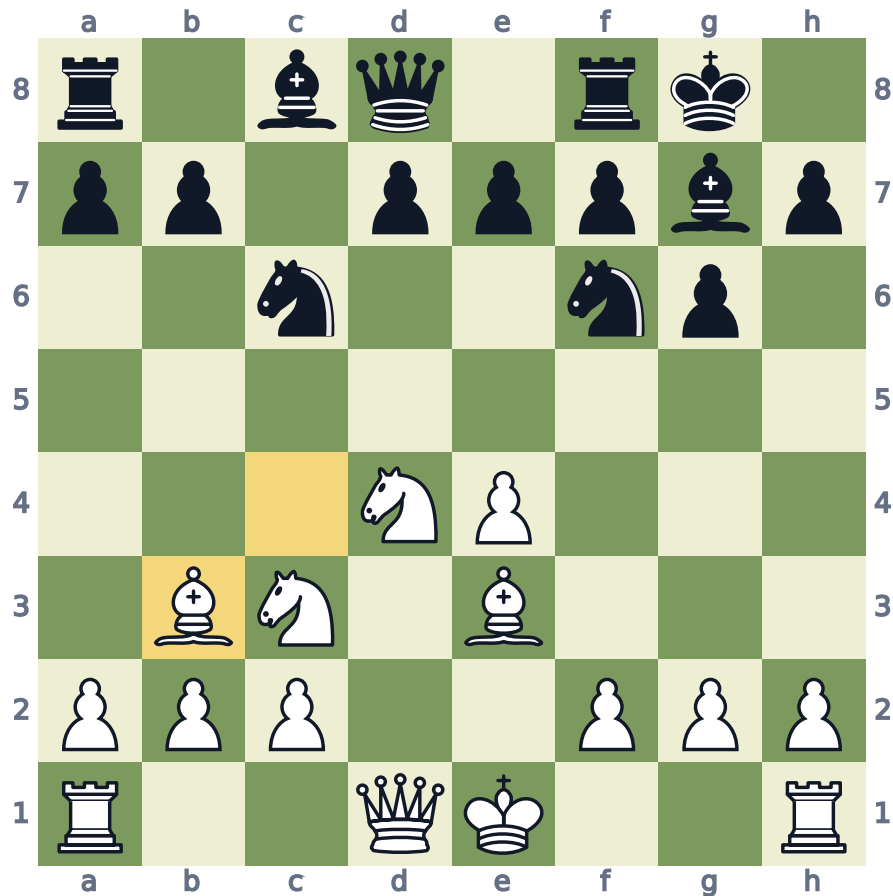
- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Strategic gains are too slow if the opponent has a concrete break, attack, or tactical resource. Recheck forcing moves whenever the position changes.

BOARD LABORATORY 30

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



5... Bg7 6. Be3 Nf6 7. Bc4 O-O 8. Bb3

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Centralize Before Switching Wings'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Central pieces have shorter paths to both wings. This flexibility makes the switch faster than the defender's lateral regrouping and reduces the risk that a flank piece becomes stranded. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Collect twelve positions connected to 'Centralize Before Switching Wings'. For each, write three candidates, the opponent's strongest reply, and a one-sentence evaluation. Revisit the same positions without notes after three and seven days; scor...

LEARNING UNIT 31

Exploit a Color Complex

THE RULE

Attack squares of the color the opponent can no longer contest effectively.

WHY IT WORKS

A traded bishop, fixed pawns, or weakened king can leave an entire color dependent on pieces poorly suited to defend it. Coordinating on those squares creates connected targets rather than one isolated weakness.

RECOGNITION CUES

there is no immediate forcing sequence; the pawn structure is stable; one side can improve a piece or create a lasting target

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Strategic gains are too slow if the opponent has a concrete break, attack, or tactical resource. Recheck forcing moves whenever the position changes.

BOARD LABORATORY 31

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



2. Nf3 e6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nc6

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Exploit a Color Complex'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A traded bishop, fixed pawns, or weakened king can leave an entire color dependent on pieces poorly suited to defend it. Coordinating on those squares creates connected targets rather than one isolated weakness. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Collect twelve positions connected to 'Exploit a Color Complex'. For each, write three candidates, the opponent's strongest reply, and a one-sentence evaluation. Revisit the same positions without notes after three and seven days; score...

LEARNING UNIT 32

Trade Space for Structural Targets

THE RULE

When cramped, consider exchanges or pawn breaks that concede territory but leave attackable pawns.

WHY IT WORKS

Space matters because it enables piece activity. If a transformation removes the opponent's active pieces and fixes weaknesses, the lost territory can be less important than the new durable targets.

RECOGNITION CUES

there is no immediate forcing sequence; the pawn structure is stable; one side can improve a piece or create a lasting target

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

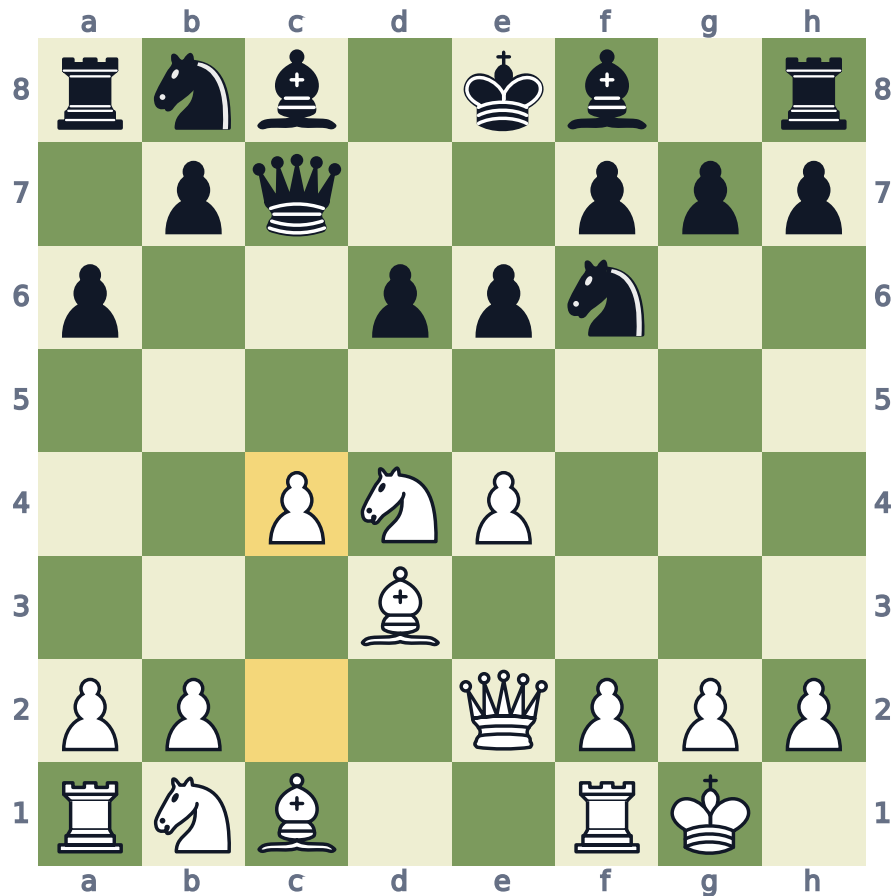
- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Strategic gains are too slow if the opponent has a concrete break, attack, or tactical resource. Recheck forcing moves whenever the position changes.

BOARD LABORATORY 32

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



5... Qc7 6. O-O Nf6 7. Qe2 d6 8. c4

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Trade Space for Structural Targets'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Space matters because it enables piece activity. If a transformation removes the opponent's active pieces and fixes weaknesses, the lost territory can be less important than the new durable targets. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Collect twelve positions connected to 'Trade Space for Structural Targets'. For each, write three candidates, the opponent's strongest reply, and a one-sentence evaluation. Revisit the same positions without notes after three and seven days; scor...

RETRIEVAL TEST

Can you explain the course without looking?

1

State the five-step decision protocol from memory.

2

Name three recognition cues that should make you slow down.

3

Choose five learning units and explain the causal mechanism behind each rule.

4

For each chosen rule, give one position where it should not be applied mechanically.

5

Describe the opponent's strongest practical resource in your most recent serious game.

6

Name one recurring error and the exact training drill that addresses its cause.

SCORING

2 points: accurate rule plus mechanism. 1 point: useful but incomplete. 0 points: slogan only. Restudy any item below 2 and retrieve it again tomorrow.

TRAINING PLAN

Four weeks to make the ideas usable

WEEK 1 - UNDERSTAND

Study the first quarter of the course. After every lesson, explain why the rule works and when it fails.

WEEK 2 - RECOGNIZE

Study the second quarter. Mix old and new diagrams so the name of the motif is not given in advance.

WEEK 3 - CALCULATE

Finish the course. Use a clock and write candidates, best defense, and endpoint evaluation.

WEEK 4 - TRANSFER

Play two slow games. Mark every moment when the course's protocol changed your decision, then analyze unaided.

LONG-TERM REVIEW

Return after 7, 14, and 30 days. Do not reread first. Attempt the retrieval test, review only missed items, and find one example from your own games.

REFERENCE

How this course fits the library

COURSE ROLE

Turn positional observations into a plan by choosing an actionable imbalance, improving coordination, and accounting for the opponent's counterplay.

LIBRARY PRINCIPLE

Strong chess comes from a loop: notice the right features, generate serious candidates, calculate the opponent's best resistance, evaluate the destination position, and learn from the decision process.

ABOUT THE DIAGRAMS

Boards use Cburnett-style vector chess pieces with solid dark pieces and high-contrast olive and cream squares. Piece artwork is credited to Colin M. L. Burnett and the Lichess Cburnett set under GPLv2+.

EDITION NOTES

First edition, September 2026. 32 learning units. Explanations and exercises are designed for personal study and should be tested against actual games and concrete calculation.

THE FINAL QUESTION

What will you do differently on your very next move? If the course has not changed a behavior, choose one rule, attach it to a visible board cue, and practice it in five slow games.